Matrix Wargame — Player Rules Handbook

You are expected to arrive at the LLAB having read, and knowing, everything in your read-ahead: this handbook, the Scenario Brief, the Player Forms, and your team's documents. Your team's documents are secret, so don't show them to the other team.

All countries, people, and events in this scenario are fictional. All military systems are real U.S. systems, described with unclassified, approximate capabilities.

Part	What it covers
1. How to play	The game in one page, the turn clock, and an example turn
2. The rules in detail	COAs, Pros and Cons, adjudication, requests, negotiation, roles, end of game
3. Reference	Doctrine cheat sheet and glossary

1. How to play

1.1 The full game, briefly

1. **What this is.** A *matrix wargame*: there is no rulebook of unit stats. You win via arguments. Each turn your team proposes **one course of action (COA)** and gives **up to three reasons it will work**. The other team gives **up to three reasons it won't**. The **white cell** weighs the reasons, sets the odds, rolls the dice (with a computer program), and narrates what happens.
2. **Your side.** You are either **REDFOR** or **BLUEFOR**. Your team's documents give you your forces, your intel, and **three secret objectives**. Don't show the other team your objectives.
3. **One COA per turn.** A COA is *one* main action with a *measurable effect*, e.g. [REDACTED]s and an [REDACTED] strike the [REDACTED] site near [REDACTED] **so that** [REDACTED] is destroyed and our ISR aircraft can operate over [REDACTED]." You can use several assets in one COA (a strike package counts as one action), but you can't do two unrelated things. Everything else your forces do is background activity.
4. **Format of your COA (2 minutes):**

"Our COA: **[action]** in order to **[measurable effect]**. It will work because: **(1)** ... **(2)** ... **(3)** ..."

5. **Format of your Cons (1 minute):**

"Their COA will fail or fall short because: **(1)** ... **(2)** ... **(3)** ..."

6. **Good reasons** are specific and grounded in facts. They point to your assets' capabilities, the map, things that happened earlier in the game ("established facts"), and doctrine (tenets of airpower, principles of joint operations). Repeating a reason in new words earns nothing.
7. **Odds.** With no strong reasons either way, a COA succeeds on 7+ on two dice (58%). Each strong reason for it adds +1, and each strong reason against it subtracts 1. If a COA is obviously sound and unopposed, it succeeds without a roll.
8. **RFIs and RFFs.** Each turn you may hand the white cell **up to 3 written requests in total**, any mix of:
    a. **RFI (Request for Information):** a question about the situation.
    b. **RFF (Request for Forces):** a request for more assets or authorities from your national command. Reinforcements take time to arrive.

Requests don't count as your COA, and there is no debate on them.

9. **Turn clock (15 minutes, run by a timer program).** See §1.2. **BLUEFOR always goes first.**
10. **No interrupting.** It's a courtroom, not a debate. You speak in your slot and are silent in theirs. Raise only points of fact or procedure. **If you miss your slot, the point is lost.** There are no do-overs.
11. **Arguing about the other side is allowed.** You can argue *their* troops are tired or *their* radar has a gap. You cannot argue that a player-controlled actor *agrees* to something. Ask them in person instead.
12. **The point** is good decisions and good reasoning under pressure: plan, communicate, brief, defend your choices, and adapt.

1.2 The turn clock

Each turn is **15 minutes** of real time and about **3 days** of game time. **Both teams' COAs take place simultaneously across the 3-day window.**

Step	Clock	Time	Who	What happens
Prepare	0:00–5:00	5:00	Both teams	Pick this turn's COA. Write up to 3 RFI/RFF slips. Negotiate if you want (§2.6, ≤ 2:00). The white cell hands back last turn's RFI answers at the start.
Hand in slips	5:00	—	Both teams	Give your RFI/RFF slips (≤ 3 combined) to the white cell. No debate.
BLUEFOR COA + Pros	5:00–7:00	2:00	BLUEFOR briefer	Action, measurable effect, up to 3 reasons
REDFOR COA + Pros	7:00–9:00	2:00	REDFOR briefer	Action, measurable effect, up to 3 reasons

Prepare Cons	9:00–11:00	2:00	Both teams	Huddle to pick up to 3 Cons against the enemy's COA
REDFOR Cons on BLUEFOR's COA	11:00–12:00	1:00	REDFOR	Up to 3 reasons BLUEFOR's COA fails or has costs
BLUEFOR Cons on REDFOR's COA	12:00–13:00	1:00	BLUEFOR	Up to 3 reasons REDFOR's COA fails or has costs
White cell resolves	13:00–15:00	2:00	White cell	Rolls, narrates, rules on RFFs, moves counters and tracks, maybe an inject

1.3 Example turn

Heavily redacted. Unredacted version will be given with scenario information at a later time.

BLUEFOR COA (2:00): "[REDACTED] [REDACTED] boats and the [REDACTED] maritime militia, covered by our [REDACTED], establish an armed maritime exclusion and inspection zone across [REDACTED], **in order to** move [REDACTED] from Restricted to **Closed**. It works because: (1) [REDACTED] are only ~[REDACTED] miles wide and sit inside our ~[REDACTED]-mile [REDACTED] umbrella, so REDFOR surface ships can't escort freighters through safely; (2) the militia's [REDACTED] boats blend in with coastal traffic and swarm any ship that tries to run [REDACTED], which gives us *surprise* and *mass*; (3) closing [REDACTED] pressures [REDACTED]'s economy and its [REDACTED] without us firing first on [REDACTED] warships."

REDFOR COA (2:00): "A strike package of [REDACTED]s and an [REDACTED], refueled by [REDACTED]s, strikes [REDACTED] covering [REDACTED], **in order to** destroy [REDACTED] and open the air over [REDACTED] for our ISR. It works because: (1) the [REDACTED] is a stealth aircraft built to penetrate integrated air defenses; (2) [REDACTED] jamming cuts [REDACTED] off from its early-warning radar network, which is *synergistic effects*; (3) the war just started, which gives us *surprise*, because [REDACTED] hasn't had time to relocate."

REDFOR Cons on BLUEFOR (1:00): "(1) [REDACTED], [REDACTED], and [REDACTED] s have been watching [REDACTED] since Phase I and will track patrol boat formations and holds. (2) Shutting down [REDACTED] by threatening merchant shipping will turn [REDACTED] against [REDACTED]."

BLUEFOR Cons on REDFOR (1:00): "(1) [REDACTED] is a mobile system, and our Phase I brief said we'd relocate [REDACTED] at the outbreak of war. (2) [REDACTED]-based fighters have to fly ~[REDACTED] miles each way, so they depend on tankers."

White cell resolution (2:00):

- **BLUEFOR [REDACTED].** Pros 1 and 2 are strong (+2). Pro 3 is about the *effect*, not about success, so it counts 0 here. REDFOR Con 1 is strong (−1), because the maritime ISR presence is an established fact. REDFOR Con 2 is about *consequences*, so it doesn't change the odds but will shape the outcome. Closing [REDACTED] with patrol boats and coastal missiles was a planned COA in BLUEFOR's Phase I brief and is still valid (+1). The COA needs NDF and [REDACTED] forces to work together, so [REDACTED] applies (−1). **Net +1.** The program rolls 6, and 6 + 1 = **7, a Partial success.** The exclusion zone is declared and shipping halts, moving Strait Traffic to **Closed**, but REDFOR [REDACTED]s and SIGINT tracked the patrol boats' patrol sectors and radar handoffs (now an established fact). [REDACTED] moves 1 toward [REDACTED].
- **REDFOR strike.** Pros 1 and 2 are strong (+2). BLUEFOR Con 1 is strong (−1), because the relocation was briefed before the war, and it cancels REDFOR Pro 3 (surprise counts 0). BLUEFOR Con 2 is true, but the [REDACTED]s are part of the package, so it counts 0. **Net +1.** The program rolls 9, and 9 + 1 = **10, a Success.** PAT-1 is caught relocating and is **Destroyed**.
- **Ongoing effect** announced: "Exclusion zone in [REDACTED]": −1 to any COA moving shipping through [REDACTED] until the coastal threat and patrol boats are suppressed.

What to take from it: specific Pros win, the best Cons attack the reasons rather than the goal, a good Phase I plan pays off, and Cons about *consequences* still matter even when they don't change the roll.

2. The rules in detail

2.1 The turn

- The steps and times are in §1.2. One turn is "a turn in the chess sense": each side acts once.
- **Fixed order.** BLUEFOR always briefs first and REDFOR second, every turn. The order never switches.
- **Simultaneous execution.** Both COAs happen at the same time across the 3-day turn window, because both are briefed before either is resolved. REDFOR, briefing second, **may react** to BLUEFOR's COA, which is realistic. It **may not** simply negate it ("their strike doesn't happen") or prevent BLUEFOR's COA from being rolled. Negating is what Cons are for; a counter-move is resolved as an interacting or opposed COA (§2.7).

2.2 Courses of action

A COA has two parts.

1. **Action:** who does what, where, and with which assets.
2. **Measurable effect:** what will be true on the map or tracks if it succeeds. Examples: "PAT-1 destroyed," "[REDACTED] Traffic moves to Open," "[REDACTED] grants combat basing," "[REDACTED] Regime Stability −1."

One action per turn. The action can be big ("mobilize the militia brigades") or a multi-asset package ("[REDACTED fighter] + [REDACTED tanker] + [REDACTED EW] strike package"), but it must serve **one** effect. Two unrelated things are two COAs. Pick one. Choosing priorities is the point.

Think beyond kinetic. Diplomatic, information, cyber, space, economic, logistics, and deception COAs are all valid and are often stronger. Use **DIME** (Diplomatic, Informational, Military, Economic) and **PMESII** (Political, Military, Economic, Social, Information, Infrastructure) as checklists.

Special cases

Case	Rule

Big projects	Take **at most 3 successful COAs**, e.g. building a coalition or standing up a dispersed ACE network. The white cell states the number up front.
Protected and hidden things	Need successful COAs to find or get through them, **no more than 3 layers**. Example: a hidden mobile SAM must first be **found** (ISR COA), then **struck**.
Long-term COAs	If the effect can't finish within one turn's 3 days, success means it **has started and continues** until someone stops it.
Announcements	Press statements and declarations are free. Your briefer can add a one-sentence public statement in the COA slot. A statement with a measurable effect ("...in order to raise International Opinion by 1") *is* a COA.

2.3 Pros and Cons

Pros are up to 3 reasons your COA will work, stated in your COA slot. **Cons** are up to 3 reasons the other team's COA will fail, be ineffective, or have minimal impact, stated in your Cons slot. The same quality rules apply to both.

Strong reasons are **specific**, **relevant**, and **grounded**. They draw on:

- **Established facts:** anything in the briefings, or anything created by an earlier successful COA. These are the strongest reasons. Building on the story is rewarded.
- **Asset capabilities and limitations** listed in the order of battle. Every asset has a stated limitation. Those are your Cons.
- **Reasonable assumptions**, e.g. "trained aircrews outperform untrained militia." Unreasonable assumptions ("the militia shoots down the stealth bomber with rifles") count for nothing.
- **Doctrine**, e.g. "This applies *mass* and *surprise* (principles of joint operations) and *concentration* (tenet of airpower)." Citing doctrine correctly and specifically counts. Name-dropping it doesn't.

Weak, vague, or duplicate reasons are worth 0. Three weak reasons are worse than one strong one, because you used up the time.

Cons about consequences ("that strike will cause civilian casualties and outrage") don't argue that the action fails. They argue it has **costs**. The white cell uses them to shape the *outcome* (side effects, track changes), not the odds.

The white cell's four questions. Before you give a reason, check it the way the white cell will:

1. **Is it true?** An established fact, a listed capability, or a reasonable assumption.
2. **Is it relevant** to *this* action and *this* effect?
3. **Is it new,** not a restatement of a reason already given?
4. **Does it matter?** Would a real commander care?

Four yeses make a strong reason (±1). One that is decisive on its own can be ±2.

Intelligence reports are not established facts. Your intel products may be wrong. A Pro built on a report counts only as far as the report is believable, so confirm important reports with an RFI or an ISR COA first.

2.4 Secret COAs

- Use these for **misdirection or conditional traps** only, e.g. decoy SAM sites, a honeypot network, booby-trapped port facilities. Don't use them for ordinary actions you'd simply rather hide.
- Each team may make **one secret COA per phase**.
- Write it on a slip with a **precise trigger** (Player Forms), hand it to the white cell, and announce "We are making a secret COA." That is your COA for the turn. The other team can't give Cons against something it can't see.
- The white cell resolves it **when the trigger occurs**. A trigger written too loosely doesn't fire. Precision is your job.

2.5 Arguing about other actors

Actor	Can you argue about it?
Your own forces	Yes. That's normal.
The opposing team's forces	**Yes.** Argue about their morale, readiness, maintenance, gaps. You can't give them orders.

A **player-controlled** actor's *decisions* (the other team)	**No.** You can't argue "BLUEFOR agrees to a ceasefire." Ask them in person during Prepare. If they agree, it happens.
White-cell-controlled actors (other nations, populations, pirates, the press, weather)	Yes, through COAs. The white cell adjudicates.

2.6 Negotiation

- During **Prepare**, your flight commander (or a delegate) may ask the lead adjudicator for a **parley** with the other team. It lasts **up to 2 minutes**, taken out of Prepare.
- Whatever the players agree in person **happens**, with no roll. Examples: prisoner exchanges, a local ceasefire, an agreement to open talks, a deal to let shipping through.
- Agreements are not self-enforcing. You may break one, but the broken deal becomes an **established fact** that others can use in Pros and Cons, and the white cell may move tracks.

2.7 How the white cell decides

The white cell makes the final decision. It works through each COA like this:

1. **Screen.** Is the COA feasible within 3 days, the map, and the assets you actually have? If not, it is ruled **impossible** (no roll) or **scoped down**.
2. **Automatic success.** If there were no credible Cons, or the case is overwhelming, it **succeeds without a roll**.
3. **Count modifiers** (net total capped at **±4**):

Modifier	Value
Each **strong** Pro	+1 (an exceptional one may be +2)
Each **strong** Con	−1 (an exceptional one may be −2)
Weak, vague, or duplicate reason	0
Planned COA executed as briefed and still valid	+1

Starting conditions or ongoing effects that apply (Scenario Brief §6)	±1 each
An asset used in the COA is **Degraded**	−1

4. **Roll 2d6** in the dice program, add the modifiers, and read the result:

Total	Result	Meaning
≤ 3	**Critical failure**	Fails, and something goes wrong: losses, exposure, backlash, a track moves against you.
4–6	**Failure**	Doesn't happen, or has no meaningful effect. Assets may be Degraded if it was a risky combat action.
7–8	**Partial success**	Happens, but limited or at a cost (e.g. target Degraded instead of Destroyed).
9–11	**Success**	Happens as argued.
≥ 12	**Exceptional success**	Happens, plus a bonus: an extra effect, a new established fact, or a track moves in your favor.

5. **Narrate.** The white cell gives the result and the reason in a sentence or two. Successful results become **established facts**.

Your odds at a glance

Net modifier	−4	−3	−2	−1	0	+1	+2	+3	+4
Natural roll needed	11+	10+	9+	8+	7+	6+	5+	4+	3+
Chance of at least Partial	8%	17%	28%	42%	58%	72%	83%	92%	97%

When COAs interact or collide. Both COAs happen simultaneously across the 3-day turn window. If one affects the other's odds (e.g. BLUEFOR disperses SAMs while REDFOR strikes them), the white cell folds that into the modifiers. If both teams' COAs can't both

succeed (e.g. both try to seize the same port), the program rolls for each side, each adds its own modifiers, and the higher total wins. A tie is a stalemate: both are Partial.

No recalculation. An objection raised late (after its slot, or after the roll) **is not considered**, and a result is not re-run once announced.

2.8 Counters and fog of war

- **Counter states: Ready** · **Degraded** (−1 when used) · **Destroyed** (removed).
- **Visible** counters start on the central map, where both teams can see them.
- **Hidden** counters stay on your team sheet. The enemy doesn't know about them until they are found by a successful ISR COA, revealed by their own use, or disclosed by an inject. Once a hidden counter is used, it goes on the map.
- **RFI answers** reflect what your intelligence would plausibly know. They may be incomplete, uncertain ("unknown"), or wrong if the enemy has succeeded at deception. RFIs never reveal the enemy's secret objectives or secret COAs.
- **Injects** are events the white cell introduces, such as weather, civilian events, leaks, and third-party moves. There is at most one per turn. Injects may also set new national directives.
- **Ongoing effects** announced by the white cell ("burning port," "exclusion zone in [REDACTED]") persist and can give ±1 to related COAs until a successful COA removes them.

2.9 Requests: RFIs and RFFs

	RFI – Request for Information	**RFF – Request for Forces**
Purpose	Ask what your side knows: enemy disposition, weather, a third party's stance, the civilian situation	Ask your national command for more assets or authorities
Limit	**Up to 3 per turn, RFIs and RFFs combined**	Shared with RFIs
Format	One question per slip, one sentence	Asset (from your RFF pool, or a free-text request), destination, and purpose

Answer	A short written answer at the start of the next Prepare	Approved, partly approved, or denied, with the **arrival turn**

- Forces that arrive by RFF **do nothing on the turn they arrive** unless the timing table says otherwise.
- A big RFF (a carrier strike group, a ground brigade, permission to strike [REDACTED], the enemy capital) is a **political** decision. The white cell may deny it, or demand a successful COA first to build the case.

2.10 Roles

Role	Who	Job
Flight commander	Assigned	Leads the team, makes the final call, and briefs
Everyone else	Commander's choice	Operations, intel, logistics, briefing, and anything else your team decides it needs
Lead adjudicator	White cell	Runs the clock, the dice, and injects. Final authority.
Loggers	White cell (one per side)	Hear briefs and move counters

You **may use computers** during play. The decisions and briefs must be your team's own.

2.11 End of game

After Turn 7 the white cell states the final map and tracks, then scores each team's three secret objectives as **Achieved**, **Partial**, or **Not achieved**. The two sides' objectives aren't always opposed, so it is possible for both teams to achieve something. Talking to the other team can pay off.

3. Reference

3.1 Doctrine cheat sheet

Cite these by name in your Pros and Cons, and say *how* they apply.

Tenets of airpower (AFDP 3-0)

Tenet	In one line
Mission command	Centralized command, distributed control, decentralized execution: subordinates act on the commander's intent
Flexibility and versatility	Airpower can shift quickly between targets, missions, and theaters, and one asset can do many jobs
Synergistic effects	Coordinated forces produce effects greater than the sum of their parts
Persistence	Airpower can keep up pressure over time (tankers, ISR orbits, repeated strikes)
Concentration	Mass airpower at the decisive point and time. Don't spread it thin.
Priority	Limited assets go to the most important effects first
Balance	Weigh opportunity against risk and resources

Principles of joint operations (AFDP 3-0, JP 3-0): **objective**, **offensive**, **mass**, **maneuver**, **economy of force**, **unity of command**, **security**, **surprise**, **simplicity**, **restraint**, **perseverance**, **legitimacy**, plus **unity of effort**.

USAF core functions (AFDP 3-0): Air Superiority (**AS**), Global Precision Attack (**GPA**), Rapid Global Mobility (**RGM**), Global ISR (**GISR**), Command and Control (**C2**).

COA validity tests (AFDP 5-0). The white cell screens every COA against these, so you should too:

Test	Ask yourself

Feasible	Can we do it in 3 days with what we actually have, where it actually is?
Acceptable	Is the gain worth the risk and the cost?
Suitable	Does it move us toward our objectives?
Distinguishable	Is it really different from what we did last turn?
Complete	Does it say who, what, where, when, and why?

Agile Combat Employment (ACE) (AFDP 3-0 App. C): dispersing to a network of smaller locations complicates enemy targeting, but it needs C2, logistics, and base defense to work.

DIME instruments of power: Diplomatic, Informational, Military, Economic. **PMESII** dimensions: Political, Military, Economic, Social, Information, Infrastructure. Run through both when you need a non-kinetic idea.

3.2 Glossary

Term	Meaning
COA	Course of action: the one action a team argues for each turn
Pro / Con	A reason for or against a COA's success
Established fact	Anything in the briefings or created by a successful COA. It stays true until another COA changes it.
Reasonable assumption	Something any professional would accept without proof (trained troops beat untrained ones)
RFI / RFF	Request for Information / Request for Forces
Inject	A white cell event that changes the situation
White cell	The neutral control group: the lead adjudicator and loggers

REDFOR / BLUEFOR	The two opposing player sides, and the neutral or unaligned third actor
Counter	A printed piece on the map representing an asset or effect
Track	A marker beside the map for something abstract (opinion, stability)
Ready / Degraded / Destroyed	Asset states. A Degraded asset gives −1 when used. A Destroyed one is removed.
Visible / Hidden	Whether a counter is on the map for the enemy to see, or only on your team sheet
DIME / PMESII	Instruments of power / dimensions of effect. A checklist for non-kinetic ideas.
ACE	Agile Combat Employment: operating from a dispersed network of locations
ISR	Intelligence, surveillance, and reconnaissance
HUMINT / SIGINT / IMINT / OSINT	Intelligence from human sources / intercepted signals / imagery / open sources (news, social media)
SOF	Special operations forces
SAM	Surface-to-air missile